Pereire. It was a comfortable flat on the fourth floor, to the right on exiting the lift, and that's how the flat was referred to—'quatrième droite' or 'fourth right'. In those days, there was no concept of international schools, so we had to go to whichever was the local district school. My sister and brother went off to the secondary girls' and boys' schools, the boys' school being at 16, Rue Laugier, where I would join about a year later. But till then, I had to go to the primary school which was somewhere on the Bd Pereire, within walking distance of the house. Those initial days were quite difficult for me. For a young boy, not yet six, who was not even willing to go in a different rickshaw to school, going alone to a strange school in a foreign land with zero knowledge of French, was quite distressing. I have vivid memories of those early days, of not being able to communicate at all—not even being able to request permission to go to the washroom. I remember one occasion when another boy had 'borrowed' my pencil sharpener, and I could not convey that to the teacher. This strange set of circumstances forced us, and I say us because I'm sure my siblings would have had the same problem, to learn the language super quick. Necessity is the mother of invention, but necessity is equally the mother of learning. It was a matter of survival in a foreign land.

I cannot now say exactly when, but within a few short months, we were speaking French like the French. The credit for that should go to my parents because one of the first things they did was buy a TV and encourage us to watch it. The programmes were all in French, subtitles unheard of, and we learnt by watching, picking up the language, the nuances and the accent. We soon even started to come first in class. I became confident enough to start walking to and from school by myself, even during the winters, in my anorak and balaclava. My father filmed me once on his cine camera, walking home

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